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My Microsoft Cloud Solution Architect Job Interview Experience

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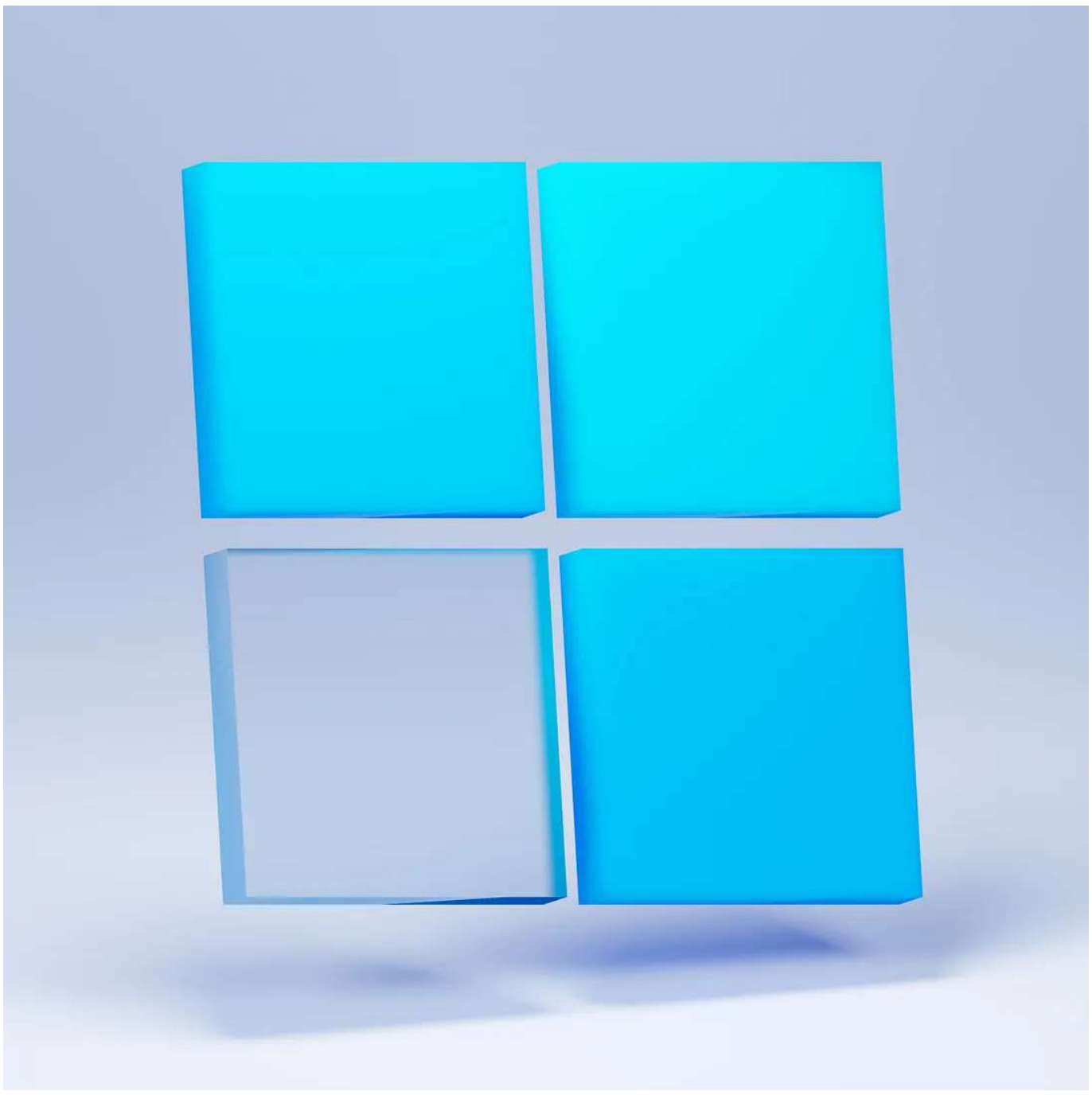


Photo by Sunder Muthukumaran on Unsplash

Introduction

Hi there, I’m EC! I’m a Cloud professional based in Brisbane, Australia.

I am a career changer. Nice meeting you here :)

Before switching career to the tech industry, I was an admin officer in the accounting industry. Later I decided to quit my stable full-time job and went to study a 6-month intense full-stack web development bootcamp. My first job offer after the bootcamp was a Cloud Architect at Amazon Web Services (AWS) Australia.

After AWS, I joined Microsoft Australia as a Cloud Solution Architect and today I'd like to share my interview experience back in August 2022.

There were 3 rounds of interview with Microsoft and the process was much straightforward compared to AWS (I had 6 rounds of interviews with AWS when I joined 😝).

Microsoft Phone Screening with Recruiter

I came across this position on LinkedIn. A few days after I submitted my application, I received a call from a Microsoft sourcing recruiter. In that phone call, we had a quick chat on why I wanted to apply to this job and some basic screening questions.

Instead of asking my salary expectations, he surprised me by sharing the salary details with me. He outlined the entire salary package, which included the base salary, car allowance, performance bonus and stocks (RSUs). He told me that he wanted to make sure that I was happy with what Microsoft offered before he kicked off the actual interview and he didn't want to waste my time on something that I wasn't aligned to. I was really impressed by his upfront and transparent approach!

My experience with this Microsoft souring recruiter was very positive. He was sincere, direct and knowledgeable about the position and team that he helped to recruit. He answered all my questions regarding the role, team culture, and the company's future goals etc, which set a really strong foundation for my Microsoft interview experience.

Round 1: Interview with Hiring Manager

The first interview with Microsoft was a one-hour interview with the Hiring Manager (HM). It was more of a chat with another industry professional than the traditional way of interview!

We discussed our respective roles, our current teams and our views regarding cloud technologies. I asked the HM a lot of the questions because I genuinely wanted to understand more about the role and Microsoft culture.

The interview was initially scheduled for an hour, but it actually lasted for 90 minutes and I really enjoyed my conversation with the HM.

Without any surprise, I received a call from the recruiter, informing me that I had passed the first round and he also gave me some tips about the second round of the interviews.

I found Microsoft's interview structure quite different from the usual interview process, as HMs usually are placed in the last round or the second last round of the interview process.

Microsoft Interview Round 2: Technical Interview

The second round was a technical interview with a senior Cloud Solution Architect. I felt less confident about this one as I wasn't very familiar with the Azure services. So I spent lots of time watching YouTube videos to learn more about Azure technologies before the interview.

To my surprise, the actual interview was more like having a high-level technical discussion with a colleague in the cloud industry. Same as my first Microsoft interview, I asked the interviewer many questions about the position, team culture, company culture and career development.

In my experience (as a candidate and as an interviewer), interviews for Cloud Architects or Solutions Architects tend to be less focused on coding and algorithms compared to traditional software engineering interviews. The emphasis is more on solution design and general cloud knowledge. Candidates are not expected to have deep expertise in the specific cloud platform (i.e. AWS, Azure or GCP), but rather they should demonstrate an aptitude for learning new technologies quickly.

A crucial aspect of these roles is the ability to communicate effectively with both technical and non-technical customers, understanding their needs, and proposing solutions. Sometimes, even if a candidate is technically strong, their ability to communicate with clients can determine whether they are hired or not.

Overall, I felt that this second round went well, despite my initial lack of confidence.

The next day, the recruiter called to inform me that they had decided to move on to the final round.

Microsoft Interview Round 3: Panel Interview

The final round involved an interview with Microsoft's ANZ (Australia and New Zealand) Director (the manager of my HM) and another female Cloud

Solution Architect in my perspective team.

This round of interview was very interactive, focusing on my personal experiences, reasons for switching careers and some behavioural questions.

The interview was actually just like having a conversation with senior colleagues in the cloud technology industry. We discussed various topics, and I continued to ask questions just like the previous two rounds. At one point, I even stopped asking questions and let the interviewers know that although I still have lots of other questions, I was happy to give them back the time on interviewing me. The Director really appreciated my enthusiasm and genuine interest in joining them.

Interview Outcome

Similarly, the day after the final round, I received an email from Recruiter 2 (a different person from the sourcing recruiter) expressing a desire to discuss interview feedback with me. During the phone call with Recruiter 2, I received a verbal offer.

After a careful consideration, I decided to embrace this brand new challenge: a new company culture, a new cloud service platform, a new role and a new city!

Overall, my experience with Microsoft's interview process was excellent. Everyone was professional, efficient and considerate. Also as you just read, the turnaround was also really fast — they usually let me know the outcome the next day.

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